

# Golden Thread — Obsidian & Daily Workflow Guide

**Reader:** someone working in Obsidian alongside sessions **Claims last checked against the code:** 2026-09-16 — see *The documents, and what belongs in each* in [CLAUDE.md](#) .

How to use Golden Thread day-to-day, combining Obsidian as your reading/navigation layer with Claude Code skills as your writing layer.

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## The Division of Labor

| YOU USE...         | FOR...                                                             |
|--------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Obsidian           | Reading, browsing, graph navigation, search, reviewing what exists |
| Claude Code skills | Writing, updating, promoting, maintaining the vault                |

The vault is plain markdown files. Obsidian is the human GUI. Claude Code is the AI's write interface. You can edit vault files directly in Obsidian — but the skills handle the ceremony (frontmatter, cross-links, log entries, index updates) so you don't have to.

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# How the Vault Looks in Obsidian

## THE FILE TREE

```
GoldenThreadVault/
  CLAUDE.md          ← AI instructions (don't edit manually)
  index.md           ← Knowledge page catalog – your navigation hub
  log.md             ← audit trail of every operation
  review-queue.md    ← items flagged for your review

  Sources/           ← raw ingested docs – never edit these
  Knowledge/         ← cross-project wiki pages
    _template.md     ← page format reference (don't use as a page)

  global-memory/     ← facts loaded in every Claude session
    MEMORY.md        ← one-line index (this is what Claude reads)

  Projects/
    README.md        ← master project list (open this first)
    CONVENTIONS.md   ← how projects are structured
    PROTOCOL.md      ← cross-project process rules
    INFRASTRUCTURE.md ← your server fleet (defined once, linked everywhere)

  shel/              ← a project
    README.md        ← status board – your daily check-in file
    idea.md          ← origin story (never changes)
    research.md       ← findings (append-only)
    decisions.md      ← ADRs (append-only)
    design.md         ← current architecture
    runbook.md        ← operational commands
    harvester/        ← sub-project (same structure)
    memory/
      MEMORY.md      ← session memory index
```

## KEY OBSIDIAN VIEWS

- **Graph view** — shows how Knowledge pages link to each other. Clusters reveal related areas. Isolated nodes are orphans ( `gt-lint` will catch them).
  - **Backlinks panel** — open a page and see everything that links to it. Use this to understand impact before changing a Knowledge page.
  - **Search** — vault-wide full text. Faster than `gt-query` for exact strings you know exist.
  - **Tag pane** — project tags from `README.md` frontmatter. Useful for filtering by domain.
  - **Dataview plugin** (required) — `Projects/README.md` and `TASKS.md` contain Dataview queries that render the live project and task tables; see [Plugins](#).
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## Plugins

The reference vault's plugin set, verified on 2026-09-08 against `.obsidian/community-plugins.json`, each plugin's `manifest.json`, and `.obsidian/core-plugins.json`. Theme is the default; no CSS snippets.

## COMMUNITY PLUGINS, ENABLED (15)

| PLUGIN          | ID                                      | VERSION | WHAT IT DOES                           | GOLDEN THREAD USE                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
|-----------------|-----------------------------------------|---------|----------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Dataview        | <code>dataview</code>                   | 0.5.68  | Queries over vault metadata            | <b>Required.</b> 3 queries in <code>Projects/README.md</code> , 3 in <code>TASKS.md</code> ("Live views"); indexes the inline task fields ( <code>p</code> , <code>waiting</code> , <code>since</code> , <code>due</code> ) |
| Terminal        | <code>terminal</code>                   | 3.27.1  | Consoles and shells inside Obsidian    | Claude Code in a pane beside the notes (default profiles; nothing custom)                                                                                                                                                   |
| Calendar        | <code>calendar</code>                   | 1.5.10  | Calendar of daily notes                | Daily-notes navigation for the review sweep                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| Text Extractor  | <code>text-extractor</code>             | 0.7.0   | OCR from images and PDFs               | Ingesting scanned sources                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| Advanced Tables | <code>table-editor-obsidian</code>      | 0.23.2  | Table navigation, formatting, formulas | Hand-editing task and inventory tables                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| Templater       | <code>templater-obsidian</code>         | 2.25.0  | Templates with scripting               | Optional; no templates folder is configured in the reference vault                                                                                                                                                          |
| Excalidraw      | <code>obsidian-excalidraw-plugin</code> | 2.26.4  | Drawings                               | Design sketches                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| Auto Card Link  | <code>auto-card-link</code>             | 1.2.3   | URL → card-style link                  | Capturing web sources                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| URL Formatter   | <code>url-formatter</code>              | 1.2.0   | Pasted URL → <code>[text](url)</code>  | The "paste a link, get Markdown" behaviour                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| Recent Files    | <code>recent-files-obsidian</code>      | 1.7.10  | Recently opened list                   | Convenience                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| Home tab        | <code>home-tab</code>                   | 1.2.2   | Browser-like start tab                 | Convenience                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| Iconize         | <code>obsidian-icon-folder</code>       | 2.14.7  | Icons on files and folders             | Convenience                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |

| PLUGIN         | ID                                   | VERSION | WHAT IT DOES                     | GOLDEN THREAD USE |
|----------------|--------------------------------------|---------|----------------------------------|-------------------|
| Style Settings | <code>obsidian-style-settings</code> | 1.0.9   | Theme/plugin CSS variables       | Convenience       |
| Trash Explorer | <code>obsidian-trash-explorer</code> | 1.2.4   | Restore from <code>.trash</code> | Recovery          |
| BRAT           | <code>obsidian42-brat</code>         | 2.2.0   | Install beta plugins             | Beta installs     |

### INSTALLED BUT DISABLED (3)

| PLUGIN       | ID                        | VERSION | NOTE                                                                                                         |
|--------------|---------------------------|---------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Omnisearch   | <code>omnisearch</code>   | 1.30.1  | Full-text search engine. Listed as in use by the owner but <b>off</b> in the config; turn it on or remove it |
| Auto Linkify | <code>auto-linkify</code> | 1.0.0   | Also formats pasted URLs; superseded by URL Formatter, so off is right                                       |
| Claudian     | <code>realclaudian</code> | 2.0.40  | Embeds Claude Code and other agents in the vault; off (Terminal covers it)                                   |

### CORE PLUGINS

On: Files ( `file-explorer` ), Search ( `global-search` ), Quick switcher, Graph view, Backlinks, Outgoing links, Tags view ( `tag-pane` ), Canvas, Properties, Page preview, Daily notes, Templates, Note composer, Command palette, Editor status, Bookmarks, Outline, Word count, File recovery, **Sync**, Bases.

Off: Footnotes, Slash commands, Importer, Unique note creator, Random note, Slides, Audio recorder, Workspaces, Publish, Web viewer.

Two of these matter beyond convenience. **File recovery** is the only undo for an edit that a session made and git never saw. **Sync** is Obsidian Sync: in the reference vault the toggle is on but no sync vault is connected (there is no `.obsidian/sync.json` ), so nothing syncs and nothing conflicts with Dropbox. If you ever connect one, keep the vault out of any other synced folder first: two sync engines on one folder is a conflict source, and neither knows about `.git` .

## Daily Workflow — Step by Step

### MORNING: START A SESSION

1. Check your project status in Obsidian

Open `Projects/<slug>/README.md` . The status board shows sub-projects, current phase, and next action. This is your daily brief — read it before opening Claude Code.

## 2. Open the project in Claude Code

```
/gt:gt-open <project-slug>
```

Claude reads all project docs (idea → research → decisions → design → spec → runbook) plus the memory index, then summarizes: current stage, next action, blockers. Ask it to load specific memory files if you need session state from last time.

## 3. (Optional) Check the wiki

If you're about to work on something that might already be documented:

```
/gt:gt-wiki <question>
```

The wiki is checked before the web — if your team has already figured something out, it's here.

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## DURING THE SESSION: ACTIVE WORK

### Looking something up

```
/gt:gt-query <question>
```

Reads `index.md` , follows wikilinks, falls back to grep. Use this for platform behavior, conventions, past decisions. If a result shows `status: stale` , verify it before acting on it.

### Adding a source to the wiki

```
/gt:gt-wiki-ingest <url or file path>
```

Stores the source immutably, discusses what pages it should generate, then waits for your approval before writing anything. The `index.md` and `log.md` entries are written by a script ( `wiki_log.py` ), so they always have the same shape.

### Making a decision mid-session

Don't wait until `gt-work` for architectural decisions. Capture them immediately:

"Add an ADR: we're switching from polling to webhooks because..."

Claude will write the numbered ADR to `decisions.md` . ADRs are append-only — to reverse one, add a new ADR that supersedes it.

## Writing something to the runbook

Any command, landmine, or setup step worth keeping:

"Add this to the runbook: `node setup.js` must be re-run after token expiry (~24h)"

Claude appends it to `runbook.md`. Runbook is the incubator — facts that survive several sessions get promoted to the repo's `CLAUDE.md`.

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## END OF SESSION: WRITE BACK

```
/gt:gt-work
```

The most important command. Claude will:

- Append dated findings to `research.md`
- Add any new ADRs to `decisions.md`
- Rewrite `design.md` if the architecture changed
- Update `memory/*.md` with session state
- Create `spec.md` if design is complete enough to hand off
- Update the `stage:` property on the README if the project phase changed

**What not to skip:** if you close the session without running `gt-work`, those findings exist only in Claude's context and are gone when the session ends.

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## WEEKLY / PERIODIC

Review daily notes

```
/gt:gt-review
```

Scans your Obsidian daily notes for tasks and ideas that were captured there but never promoted into a tracked project. Surfaces them grouped by date and lets you route each one.

Graduate a finding

```
/gt:gt-promote
```

Use when a fact has proven true across more than one project. Promotes it from project memory → `Knowledge/` → `global-memory/`. Also handles retiring stale content and scaffolding new projects.

Check sources for changes

```
/gt:gt-wiki-refresh
```

Checks sources with `local:` or `url:` fields for upstream changes. For sources from a local git repo, `wiki_refresh.py` asks git directly — `git fetch`, then `git diff` from the commit recorded in the source's `upstream_sha:` — so detection needs no LLM judgement. Web-only sources are fetched and compared by Claude. Changed sources are superseded with new immutable files — the old source is never edited.

#### Lint the vault

```
/gt:gt-lint
```

Runs deterministic checks and reports findings grouped by type. You approve each fix — nothing is auto-applied. Declines are recorded in `lint-declines.md` so they don't get re-raised.

#### Lint runbooks

```
/gt:gt-runbook-lint
```

Scans all `runbook.md` files for procedures that have drifted into multiple runbooks. Routes duplicates to the right shared layer.

#### Lint the wiki

```
/gt:gt-wiki-lint
```

10 checks on the wiki: broken links, orphans, missing reciprocal links, unsourced pages, superseded sources still cited, review-due pages, index mismatches, status schema errors, declared expiries, and unlinked mentions.

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## Full Command Reference

### SETUP (RUN ONCE)

| COMMAND                       | WHEN TO USE                                                                                                                                                                      |
|-------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <code>/gt:gt-init</code>      | First install on a new machine, or wiring an existing vault to a new project. Idempotent — safe to re-run.                                                                       |
| <code>/gt:gt-wiki-init</code> | Set up a new wiki vault from scratch. Creates <code>Sources/</code> , <code>Knowledge/</code> , <code>index.md</code> , <code>log.md</code> , and seeds <code>CLAUDE.md</code> . |

## EVERY SESSION

| COMMAND                                               | WHEN TO USE                                                                                                                                                                                       |
|-------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <code>/gt:gt-open</code><br><code>&lt;slug&gt;</code> | <b>Start of every session.</b> Loads project context and asks where to pick up.                                                                                                                   |
| <code>/gt:gt-route</code>                             | <b>Any time in the middle.</b> Names what the session has become, where its output belongs, and whether the project, harness and model are right. Cheap — run it whenever the ground has shifted. |
| <code>/gt:gt-work</code>                              | <b>End of every session.</b> Writes back findings, decisions, design updates, memory state. Do not skip.                                                                                          |

## DURING WORK

| COMMAND                                                        | WHEN TO USE                                                                                           |
|----------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <code>/gt:gt-query</code><br><code>&lt;question&gt;</code>     | Look something up in the vault before going to the web.                                               |
| <code>/gt:gt-wiki &lt;question&gt;</code>                      | Query the structured wiki knowledge base.                                                             |
| <code>/gt:gt-wiki-ingest</code><br><code>&lt;source&gt;</code> | Add a URL, file, or pasted content to the wiki. Stores immutably, generates pages with your approval. |

## PROMOTION AND GROWTH

| COMMAND                     | WHEN TO USE                                                                                |
|-----------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <code>/gt:gt-create</code>  | Scaffold a new project. Captures your brain dump into the immutable <code>idea.md</code> . |
| <code>/gt:gt-ingest</code>  | Import an existing project's notes, memory files, and CLAUDE.md rules into the vault.      |
| <code>/gt:gt-promote</code> | Graduate a fact up the hierarchy when a second project proves it general.                  |
| <code>/gt:gt-review</code>  | Pull uncaptured items from Obsidian daily notes into tracked projects.                     |

MAINTENANCE (WEEKLY OR AS NEEDED)

| COMMAND             | WHEN TO USE                                                                       |
|---------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| /gt:gt-lint         | Audit vault structure: broken links, orphans, unlisted memory files, stale pages. |
| /gt:gt-runbook-lint | Find procedures duplicated across project runbooks.                               |
| /gt:gt-refresh      | Check Sources/ for upstream changes and supersede outdated ones.                  |
| /gt:gt-wiki-lint    | Health-check the wiki vault.                                                      |
| /gt:gt-wiki-refresh | Check wiki sources for upstream changes.                                          |

What to Edit in Obsidian vs. Claude Code

| FILE                      | EDIT IN OBSIDIAN?                                | EDIT VIA SKILL?                  |
|---------------------------|--------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------|
| Projects/<slug>/README.md | Yes — status board updates                       | gt-work updates stage            |
| research.md               | Read freely; add a dated note if you must        | gt-work for session findings     |
| decisions.md              | Read only — append-only, don't edit past entries | gt-work / mid-session ask        |
| design.md                 | Yes — light edits fine                           | gt-work for architecture changes |
| runbook.md                | Yes — add commands directly                      | Mid-session ask or gt-work       |
| Knowledge/*.md            | Yes — corrections fine                           | gt-wiki-ingest for new pages     |
| Sources/*                 | Never — immutable                                | gt-wiki-refresh for changes      |
| global-memory/*.md        | Light edits fine                                 | gt-promote for promotion         |
| CLAUDE.md                 | Avoid — AI reads this at session start           | Skills seed and update this      |
| index.md                  | Read only                                        | Updated automatically by skills  |
| log.md                    | Read only — append-only audit trail              | Updated automatically by skills  |

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## The Promotion Ladder

When a fact graduates, it moves up:

```
memory/*.md      this session, this project detail
  ↓ gt-work
research.md      settled finding, this project
  ↓ gt-promote
Knowledge/       true across multiple projects
  ↓ gt-promote
global-memory/   needed in every session, every project
```

**The rule:** promote when a second project hits the same truth. File narrow when unsure — promotion is cheap, and a fact promoted too early becomes a rule that isn't true everywhere.

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## Tips for Obsidian

- Start from **Projects/README.md** not the file tree — it's the master index.
- Follow **wikilinks** in Knowledge pages — the graph is the navigation system, not folders.
- Use **backlinks** before editing a Knowledge page to see what depends on it.
- **index.md** is the Knowledge entry point — every page is one hop from there.
- **log.md** tells you what happened — if something looks wrong, check the log first.
- **review-queue.md** is written by **gt-lint** — check it after every lint run.